balance coming through NHSRCL—a special purpose vehicle (SPV) floated by the Union ministry of railways (holding 50 per cent of equity), along with the state governments of Gujarat and Maharashtra (25 per cent equity each).

NHSRCL plans to operate two types of services on the corridor—a rapid one with only two stoppages at Surat and Vadodara that will complete the journey in 2.07 hours, and a slower service with 10 stops that will take 2.58 hours, still much faster than the existing options (see *High-speed Travel*). The reduced travel time is expected to make Surat, Vadodara and Ahmedabad in Gujarat veritable extensions of Mumbai, facilitating comfortable day trips and, as urban planners hope, even daily commutes to ease the pressure on the congested metropolis. Each train will have 10 coaches with a total seating capacity of 690. The first batch of coaches is expected to reach India by the end of 2025, post which a 50-km trial run will take place between Surat and Bilimora in August 2026. Commercial operations are scheduled to begin in 2027, with the plan to run bullet trains every hour throughout the day.

ACQUISITION ISSUES

An HSR line for India was first conceived in 2009. Soon after, a pre-feasibility study was initiated for the Mumbai-Ahmedabad corridor, followed by similar studies for other corridors (see *Extending the Network*). A joint feasibility study report submitted by JICA in July 2015 became the basis of the MAHSR project. If everything had gone according to plan, the bullet train would have been on the tracks by now, well in time for the 2024 Lok Sabha election. But the Covid-19 pandemic hit land acquisition, and combined with the farmers' protest in Gujarat and the change of government in Maharashtra, the process came to a grinding halt. In fact, farmers in at least two districts of Gujarat are still legally contesting the compensation awarded to them.

In Bharuch's Kelod village, for instance, Nipul Patel, a local BJP functionary till about two months ago, is leading a group that has refused to allow the Viksit Bharat Sankalp Yatra—a nationwide campaign to raise awareness about government schemes—enter the village. He cites the example of Bharuch's Juna Diva village, where 105 farmers have refused to take compensation even after losing their land. "The matter is now in court," says Patel, who is also an agriculturist and one of the petitioners.

The compensation was paid in accordance with the Land Acquisi-

NHSRCL HAS ACQUIRED 1389.5 HECTARES OF LAND FOR THE PROJECT. A SPOKESPERSON SAYS THAT AN ELEVATED VIADUCT MINIMISED THE NEED FOR LAND AND REDUCED THE OVERALL ENVIRONMENTAL IMPACT

PROGRESS REPORT

With commercial operations scheduled to begin in 2027, here's how the work is progressing so far



ON TRACK Work underway at Kalupur in Ahmedabad

- 100% land acquisition completed in Gujarat, Dadra & Nagar Haveli and Maharashtra
- All civil engineering contracts awarded in Gujarat and Maharashtra
- The laying of first RC track bed as used in Shinkansen has started in Surat and Anand
- First mountain tunnel (350m) completed in Valsad in 10 months; work on India's first undersea rail tunnel (7 km) has started in Mumbai
- First steel bridge (70m) erected across NH-53 in Surat; bridge works on six rivers completed
- Foundation work done for all eight stations in Gujarat
- Excavation work for the Mumbai station, geotech work for other three stations in Maharashtra underway